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ARTICLE

Prepared, Vigilant, Unafraid: The Lesson From America's Latest Terror Attacks

AAFP WHOLE HEALTH SUMMIT
You're not alone in this journey.

BY PNW STAFF MARCH 13, 2026

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When evil strikes close to home, the question every society must answer is simple but profound: will we stand, or will we surrender to fear?

In the shadow of rising tensions overseas--particularly the escalating conflict involving Iran--Americans are once again confronting a harsh reality: war abroad often fuels violence at home. The nation has witnessed a disturbing series of incidents tied to extremism and domestic terror fears.

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A bar shooting in Austin by an Islamic terrorist. Two teenage ISIS sympathizers in New York attempting to detonate homemade bombs during a protest. And now two chilling attacks within hours of each other: a truck ramming and shooting at a Michigan synagogue and a terrorist-style attack at a Virginia university.

These events are sobering reminders that the threats facing America are not just thousands of miles away on distant battlefields. Sometimes they appear in our own cities, campuses, and houses of worship.

But amid the darkness, there were also powerful examples of courage--and important lessons about preparation, vigilance, and the right to defend innocent life.

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The attacker barreled through the entrance and down a hallway, striking a security officer in the process. Soon after, the vehicle burst into flames amid the chaos. But what could have become a horrific mass casualty event was stopped by something critically important: prepared security.

Temple Israel had invested in professional security measures, including armed personnel trained specifically for threats like this. When the attacker began firing, those security personnel engaged and stopped him before he could reach classrooms or crowded areas of the building.

All 140 children in the synagogue's preschool were safely evacuated. The injured security officer is expected to recover.

That outcome did not happen by accident.

In recent years, many synagogues and churches have taken the painful but necessary step of increasing security. Some have hired trained guards. Others have implemented volunteer security teams. In many cases, these groups work with local law enforcement and federal agencies to rehearse emergency scenarios--including active shooter and terrorist-style attacks.

Reports indicate Temple Israel's security had recently trained for such scenarios alongside law enforcement, including exercises coordinated with federal authorities. When the moment of crisis arrived, they were ready.

Preparation saved lives.

Heroes Without Weapons

Just hours earlier and hundreds of miles away, another act of terror unfolded at Old Dominion University in Virginia.

A gunman entered a classroom where Reserve Officers' Training Corps (ROTC) members were gathered. According to investigators, the attacker shouted extremist slogans before opening fire, killing an ROTC instructor and injuring others.

But again, the story did not end with the attacker.

The ROTC students--future military officers--refused to simply wait to be victims.

Despite the fact that they were not armed, several cadets rushed the shooter. During the struggle, they managed to subdue him and ultimately stop the attack by 'rendering him no longer alive' according to reports. Investigators say their actions almost certainly prevented additional deaths.

Their bravery came at great cost. One instructor, Lt. Col. Brandon Shah, was killed in the attack. But the actions of the students prevented the gunman from continuing his assault across the campus.

Their instinct to act--rather than freeze--saved lives.

The Principle of Self-Defense

There is an uncomfortable truth that modern society sometimes tries to avoid: evil exists, and sometimes it must be confronted.

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There may come a moment when escape is impossible. When hiding will not work. When innocent lives depend on someone stepping forward and resisting the attacker.

That moment arrived in Michigan when security personnel defended a synagogue full of children.

It arrived in Virginia when unarmed ROTC students tackled a gunman.

Both incidents remind us that self-defense is not simply a political talking point. It is a fundamental human principle.

Vigilance Without Fear

The rise of domestic terror threats is deeply troubling. Intelligence officials have long warned that international conflicts can inspire attacks within the United States. When global tensions escalate, extremist actors sometimes see an opportunity--or justification--to strike.

But the answer to that danger is not fear.

It is vigilance.

Communities can take practical steps:

Houses of worship can develop security teams and emergency plans.

Schools and campuses can train staff and students in crisis response.

Citizens can stay aware of their surroundings and report suspicious activity.

Preparedness does not mean paranoia. It means responsibility.

Temple Israel's security team understood that reality. So did the ROTC students who refused to stand by while lives were threatened.

Courage in a Dangerous Age

We live in a world where the threat of violence cannot always be eliminated. But the response to that violence still defines who we are.

Prepared communities. Courageous individuals. Citizens who remain alert but refuse to surrender to fear.

Those qualities are not signs of a fearful society.

They are the marks of a resilient one.

The attacks of the past week are tragic reminders of the dangers we face. Yet they also highlight something equally important: when evil strikes, ordinary people are still capable of extraordinary courage.

And in moments like these, courage--not terror--is what ultimately prevails.

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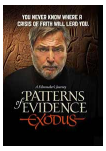

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